Here $\sin 46° = 0.72$. Hence Venus is at a distance of 0.72 AU from Sun. Similarly, the distance between Mercury (θ is 22.5 degree) and Sun is calculated as 0.38 AU. To find the distance of exterior planets like Mars and Jupiter, a slightly different method is used. The distances of planets from the Sun is given in the table below.

Table 6.2 a^3/T^2 for different planets

Planet	semi major axis of the orbit(a)	Period T (days)	a^3/T^2
Mercury	0.389 AU	87.77	7.64
Venus	0.724 AU	224.70	7.52
Earth	1.000 AU	365.25	7.50
Mars	1.524 AU	686.98	7.50
Jupiter	5.200 AU	4332.62	7.49
Saturn	9.510 AU	10,759.20	7.40

It is to be noted that to verify the Kepler's law we need only high school level geometry and trigonometry.

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Activity

Venus can be observed with the naked eye. We can see Venus during sunrise or sunset. Students are encouraged to observe the motion of Venus and verify that the maximum elevation is at 46 degree and calculate the distance of Venus from the Sun. As pointed out already Google or Stellarium will be helpful in locating the position of Venus in the sky.

6.5.3 Measurement of radius of the Earth

Around 225 B.C a Greek librarian "Eratosthenes" who lived at Alexandria measured the radius of the Earth with a small error when compared with results using modern measurements. The technique he used involves lower school geometry and

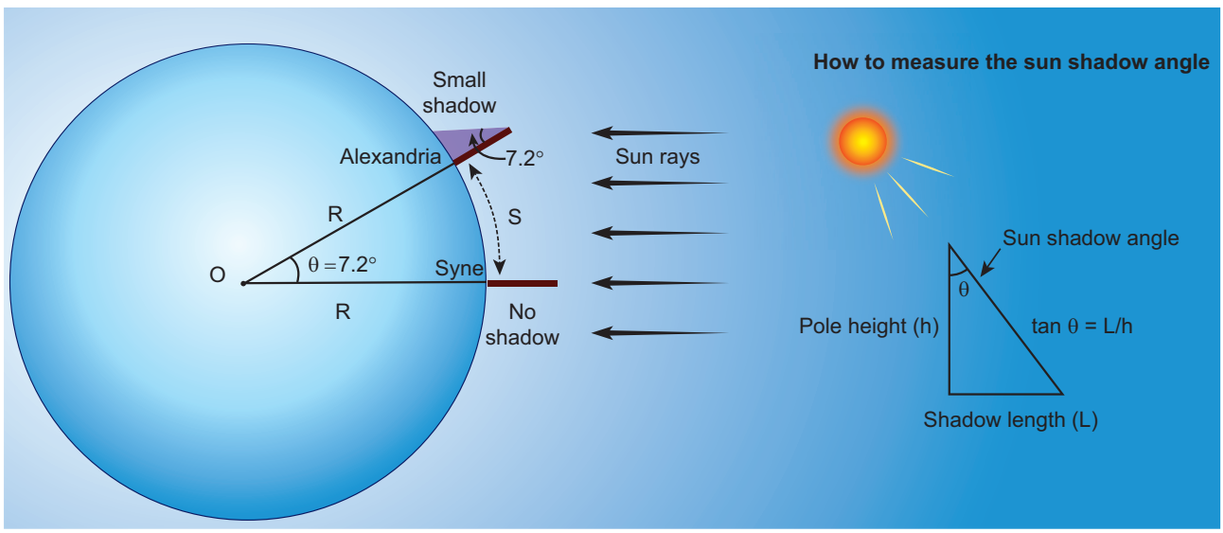


Figure 6.30 Measuring radius of The Earth

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